FREE CHECKLIST · November 2026

Site Migration SEO Checklist

Step-by-step checks from pre-launch to the first month to protect organic traffic when changing domain, platform or URL structure.

7 sections · 42 checks

How to use this checklist

Follow the sections in the order of your migration timeline and verify each item with its method once done. High priority marks steps that can cause traffic loss if skipped, medium marks checks that reduce risk, and low marks extra improvements.

Priority: **High** **Medium** **Low**

01 Scope and preparation

- [ ] Document the migration type (domain, HTTPHTTPS, platform, URL structure, design) and which URLs will change. — Medium
  How: Prepare a scope document with stakeholders; list an owner and date for each type of change.
- [ ] Schedule the launch outside the business's peak sales or campaign periods. — Medium
  How: Review monthly organic sessions for the last 12-24 months in GA4 and pick the quietest period.
- [ ] Prepare a rollback plan to use if a critical issue appears after launch. — Medium
  How: Save a backup of the old site plus DNS and server settings; decide who makes the rollback call.
- [ ] If you are moving to a new domain, check that it has no history of manual actions or spam problems. — Low
  How: Verify the new domain in Search Console and check the Manual actions report; review its past content on the Wayback Machine.
- [ ] Confirm the server can handle the increased Googlebot crawl load after the move. — Low
  How: Discuss capacity with your hosting provider; run a load test on staging.

02 Inventory and benchmark data

- [ ] Build a complete list of every URL on the old site (pages, images, PDFs, videos). — High
  How: Merge and deduplicate exports from sitemaps, a crawler, server logs, GA4, Search Console and the CMS.
- [ ] Export and archive Search Console Performance data by page and query. — High
  How: Choose the longest date range in the Performance report and export the Pages and Queries tabs (or use the API/Looker Studio).
- [ ] Record page-level organic sessions, conversions and revenue in GA4 as a benchmark. — High
  How: Export the landing page report filtered by session default channel group = Organic Search.

- [ ] **Identify the old URLs with the most external links and flag them in the mapping sheet.** Medium
  How: Export the "Top linked pages" list from the Search Console Links report and data from a backlink tool.
- [ ] **Save a full crawl snapshot of the old site's titles, meta descriptions, H1s, canonicals, hreflang and structured data.** Medium
  How: Crawl the site with a crawler and store the project and CSV export in the migration folder.
- [ ] **Record current rankings for priority keywords before the migration.** Low
  How: Set up your target keyword list in a rank tracker and start collecting data at least two weeks ahead.

03 URL mapping and 301 map

- [ ] **Prepare a redirect sheet that maps each old URL one-to-one to the closest matching new URL.** High
  How: Add a "new URL" column to the inventory; check no row is empty and every target returns 200.
- [ ] **Do not bulk-redirect many old pages to an unrelated page such as the homepage.** High
  How: Group the redirect sheet by target URL; review any target receiving many URLs one by one.
- [ ] **Use server-side 301 or 308 redirects for permanent moves.** High
  How: Test sample URLs with curl -I and check the status code and Location header; avoid JavaScript or meta refresh.
- [ ] **Update legacy redirects too so no chains form; every old URL should go straight to its final target.** Medium
  How: Merge existing redirect rules with the new sheet; check the crawler's redirect chain report.
- [ ] **Include parameterised URLs, images and PDF files in the redirect scope.** Medium
  How: Filter these file types that get traffic or links in server logs and Search Console and add them to the sheet.
- [ ] **Return a deliberate 404 or 410 for content that has no equivalent and is being removed.** Low
  How: Mark these URLs as "remove" in the sheet; still look for a relevant page for those with external links.

04 Staging checks

- [ ] **Keep the staging environment out of the index with password (HTTP authentication) or IP restriction.** High
  How: Open the staging address in a private window and confirm it asks for login; do not rely on robots.txt alone.
- [ ] **Test the entire redirect sheet on staging.** High
  How: Crawl the old URL list in list mode; confirm each row goes in one hop to the correct new URL returning 200.
- [ ] **Confirm titles, meta descriptions, H1s and main content have not been lost compared with the old site.** Medium
  How: Compare old and new crawl exports side by side via the mapping sheet.
- [ ] **Make sure canonical and hreflang tags point to the live new URLs, not staging.** High
  How: Search canonical and hreflang values for the staging domain in your crawler.
- [ ] **Confirm internal links, menus and the sitemap use the new URLs directly.** Medium
  How: Filter internal links returning 3xx and links to the old domain in the staging crawl.

- [ ] **Confirm structured data has been fully carried over to the new templates.** Medium
  How: Test one page per template in the Rich Results Test using the paste-code option.
- [ ] **Check that the new templates are no worse than the old site on Core Web Vitals.** Low
  How: Test the main templates with Lighthouse; compare LCP, CLS and total blocking time with the old site.

05 Launch day

- [ ] **Confirm the live robots.txt does not block the site and any noindex tags added during development are removed.** High
  How: Open the live robots.txt; check the main templates with "Test live URL" in the URL Inspection tool.
- [ ] **Bulk-test that redirects work in production immediately after launch.** High
  How: Recrawl the old URL list in list mode; fix 404s, 5xx errors and chains immediately.
- [ ] **Verify all variants of the new site in Search Console and upload your disavow file, if any, to the new property.** Medium
  How: Create a Domain property via DNS where possible; check both old and new sites appear as verified.
- [ ] **Submit the sitemap containing the new URLs under Search Console > Sitemaps.** Medium
  How: Confirm the status is "Success" in the Sitemaps report; keep the old sitemap in place during monitoring.
- [ ] **Use the Change of Address tool on the old property only if the domain (or subdomain) is changing.** High
  How: Do not use it for HTTPHTTPS, www/non-www switches or path changes on the same domain; 301s cover those.
- [ ] **Update website links in Google Business Profile, social profiles and paid ads to the new URLs.** Medium
  How: List every profile you control and verify each link by clicking it.

06 Analytics and tracking codes

- [ ] **Confirm the GA4 (or Google Tag Manager) tag fires on every template of the new site.** High
  How: Use Tag Assistant and GA4 DebugView to confirm page_view arrives on the main templates.
- [ ] **Confirm conversion events (forms, purchases, calls) fire on the new site under the same names.** Medium
  How: Complete each conversion path with a test transaction and check event names and parameters in DebugView.
- [ ] **If the domain changed, update the GA4 data stream URL, cross-domain settings and the Search Console link.** Medium
  How: Check the data stream and product links in GA4 Admin; link the new Search Console property.
- [ ] **Confirm ad, heatmap and other third-party tracking codes load on the new site.** Low
  How: List the tags on the old site; look for each one's request in the DevTools Network tab on the new site.
- [ ] **Log the migration date as a note in your reporting tools.** Low
  How: Add a date note to your reporting dashboard and the shared migration document; use it as the baseline later.

07 After launch: first day, week and month

- [ ] **Monitor server logs and analytics for spikes in 404 and 5xx errors in the first 24 hours.** High
  How: Filter logs by status code; add old URLs hitting 404 to the redirect sheet and deploy right away.
- [ ] **Check your 20-50 most valuable pages with the URL Inspection tool on day one.** Medium
  How: Confirm the page is indexable in the live test and request indexing if needed.
- [ ] **Track the Page indexing report on both old and new properties during the first week.** High
  How: Check that indexed pages grow on the new property and "Page with redirect" rises on the old one.
- [ ] **Use the Crawl Stats report to confirm Googlebot is crawling the new site without server errors.** Medium
  How: Review response codes and host status in the Search Console Crawl Stats report.
- [ ] **At the end of the first month, compare organic clicks, sessions and conversions page by page with the pre-migration benchmark.** Medium
  How: Join archived exports with new Search Console and GA4 data via the mapping sheet; investigate pages that declined.
- [ ] **Ask sites providing your most valuable external links to update them to the new URL.** Low
  How: Send a short update email to the sources of the highly linked URLs you flagged in the inventory.
- [ ] **Keep redirects in place for at least one year, ideally indefinitely, and keep renewing the old domain registration.** Medium
  How: Put redirect rules under version control; add the domain renewal date to your calendar.

Detailed guides

Site migration SEO guide
301 vs 302 redirects
Redirect generator
Search Console guide
SEO tracking with GA4
Technical SEO guide

Need a second pair of eyes on your site? Book a free intro call:
fatihemincakiroglu.com/en/book-a-call

This checklist reflects publicly documented Google guidance as of November 2026. Search features change; check the official documentation before major decisions.